and attitude towards Najibullah in particular. The question that if India could deal with Najibullah, who had a questionable human rights record and was a political hardliner (or was perceived to be one), then why could it not deal with the Mujahideen, was often asked. Worried that opening a channel with the Mujahideen might cost India its carefully calibrated and proven relationship with Najibullah, New Delhi had never seriously mulled a post-Najibullah scenario in Kabul. Treasuring foreign policy continuity, even if such a continuum was becoming politically costly and strategically unsound, New Delhi was averse to come across as swapping sides, and giving up on friends (in this case even a personal friendship between Najibullah and Rajiv) in a war-ridden Afghanistan.

But Najibullah himself was getting increasingly paranoid of a Khalqi coup. Despite having elevated senior Khalqi leaders such as Tanai to the chief of army staff, he only became more worried about an impending coup by late 1989 and the early 1990s. At some point the situation was so difficult that Najibullah invited Tanai for a dinner at his house and made Tanai reassure his wife that the Khalq was not planning a coup.[149] Rajiv, on his part, also began fretting about the situation by 1989 when he confidentially, but impotently, expressed his rage to Mongolian president Jambyn Batmönkh and told him that India would launch a joint war on Pakistan with Afghanistan, if Rawalpindi persisted in toppling Najibullah.[150] The misadventure in Sri Lanka, increasing separatist violence in Punjab and Kashmir, and the infamous Bofors corruption scandal, cost Rajiv his premiership in the 1989 national elections. In March 1990, with Rajiv out of the picture and Moscow in its own turmoil, Tanai and Sarwari indeed attempted a coup that failed (see prologue). Sarwari's arrest in 1990, despite Rajiv being out of power, was a tipping point that reflected New Delhi and Kabul's desperation in the face of Soviet disintegration. On 15 February 1989, the last Soviet soldier returned to Russia. In April 1992, when the Mujahideen finally did oust Najibullah, Rajiv was not alive to declare a war. His successor, P. V. Narasimha Rao, had learnt how not to repeat the same mistakes that Rajiv had made.

Conclusion